

# Practice Paper 25 — Answer Scheme

## Paper 2 — Comprehension

### Sections B & C

#### Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

#### Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

##### Q1. [2] — “There was no question of complaint”

Award **1 mark** for identifying **acceptance / resignation**; **1 mark** for explaining that she sees the failure as something **beyond her control** and therefore not worth protesting against.

**Sample answer:** The phrase suggests that the narrator **accepts the situation calmly**, because she regards the failure of the borehole as a fact of nature that **cannot be argued with** — complaining would be pointless.

##### Q2. [2] — Personification of the earth

**1 mark** for identifying **personification** — the earth is given the human ability to “decide” and to “invite”.

**1 mark** — It suggests the narrator views the situation as **final and authoritative**: the land itself has **settled the matter**, and human protest is therefore irrelevant.

##### Q3. [2] — “Seams... carefully sewn and then allowed to split”

**1 mark:** The image suggests the land was once **whole and well-made**, like a carefully constructed garment.

**1 mark:** The word **allowed** implies a kind of **neglect** — the land has been left to fall apart, which gives the dryness a sense of **quiet, slow ruin**.

##### Q4. [1] — Grass clinging like a habit

**1 mark** — It suggests the landscape is in a **state of last resort / near collapse**: the grass survives only by **desperate persistence**, as though there is **nothing else left** to sustain it.

##### Q5. [2] — The bending horizon

(a) [1]: The intense heat rising off the ground makes the air shimmer, so that distant objects appear to **wobble or float** — the horizon looks **distorted** rather than straight.

(b) [1]: She keeps her eyes near her feet because the **heat-bent horizon can deceive the eye** / cause **disorientation or hallucination**; looking close to the ground keeps her **steady and grounded**.

**Q6. [2]** — Little need to speak

**1 mark each** for any two of:

- “We did not, on these walks, talk a great deal.”
- “There was something in the act of walking together that made talking feel beside the point.”
- The schoolteacher’s widow “never spoke much” and only “nodded a greeting.”
- The shadows walking “in a neat companionable row” act as “conversation enough.”

**Q7. [3]** — Long-learned routine (language question)

**1 mark** for identifying that the routine is **practised and inherited**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “the pulley creaked in the same uncomplaining voice it had used in my mother’s time” — the well’s machinery has been in use across generations.
- “filled in turn, by an order so old that no one any longer remembered agreeing to it” — the queue follows an **unwritten, inherited custom**.
- “balanced the can on my hip the way one balances any necessary burden” — the practised verb **balanced** and the general phrase **any necessary burden** suggest **long familiarity**.
- “carefully, so that one’s back may last” — careful technique passed down to protect the body over years.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

**Q8. [2]** — “A frank and unhelpful witness”

**1 mark:** The sun is **personified** as a witness who **honestly reveals** the difficulty of her load and the length of the path.

**1 mark:** On the way home she feels **exposed** and **unsupported** — the sun **exposes her exhaustion** but offers no comfort, so the journey feels harder than it did on the way out.

**Q9. [1]** — “Gently”

**1 mark** — It suggests **affection and respect** in their relationship: the son is **careful not to wound her pride**, and they disagree **without conflict**.

**Q10. [2]** — “A life... made of such unnoticed things”

**1 mark:** She means that **most of what sustains a household and a family** is made up of **small, ordinary tasks** — washing, cooking, fetching water — that **go unappreciated**.

**1 mark:** These tasks are **invisible when done** but would be **immediately and painfully missed** if undone — so they are, in truth, what a **life is built on**.

**Q11. [1]** — Tone of the final sentence

**1 mark** — Any **one** of: **reflective, dignified, quietly self-contained, contemplative, resigned.**  
(Reject: **sad, bitter** — these miss the calm, considered quality.)

## Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

**Q12. [2]** — “Not a freak event... a preview”

**1 mark** for understanding that the Chennai crisis was **not a one-off accident** / not unusual.

**1 mark** for understanding that it was an **early example** / **warning** of what **other Asian cities** should **expect** in the coming years.

**Q13. [2]** — Causes of urban water shortage

**1 mark each** for any two of:

- **Rapid urban population growth** — over a billion more people in Asian cities by 2050.
- **Ageing, leaking pipes** — up to forty per cent of treated water lost before reaching the tap.
- **Climate change** — longer dry seasons and more intense, brief storms.
- **Aquifers being over-drawn** and **contaminated** by industrial waste, fertiliser and sewage.

**Q14. [1]** — “Prodigiously”

**1 mark** — It suggests the loss is **enormous in scale** / **extraordinarily wasteful** — far beyond what one might expect from ordinary pipe wear.

**Q15. [2]** — Jakarta’s “paradoxical” thirst

**1 mark:** A **paradox** is something that seems contradictory: it is **strange** that the city should be **sinking** because of **thirst** rather than because of flooding or weight.

**1 mark:** The contradiction is resolved when one realises that **millions of residents draw water from private wells**, which **empties the aquifers** beneath them, so the land itself **collapses into the empty space**.

**Q16. [2]** — Relocation as “an indictment”

**1 mark:** An **indictment** is a serious accusation or condemnation.

**1 mark:** The fact that an entire capital must be **abandoned and rebuilt elsewhere** is itself **evidence of failure** — it proves how badly the water and land problems have been managed, and at what **enormous cost**.

**Q17. [2]** — Singapore’s “remarkable” response

**1 mark each** for any two of:

- It built an integrated “four taps” portfolio — imports, captured rainfall, desalination and recycled waste water.
- **NEWater** purifies waste water to a standard **cleaner than most bottled brands**.
- NEWater now meets up to **forty per cent** of demand.
- Engineers from across the region travel to Singapore to **learn the technology**.

**Q18. [1]** — Effect of inverted commas around “four taps”

**1 mark** — They mark the phrase as a **coined / official term** used by Singapore’s water authorities; the inverted commas signal that it is a **metaphor** rather than four physical taps, and invite the reader to take it as a **deliberate policy label**.

**Q19. [2]** — Sentence structure showing inequality

**1 mark:** The two halves of the sentence are **parallel** in structure (“the wealthy... the poor...”), and the verbs are arranged in **threes**, which creates a direct, almost rhythmic **comparison**.

**1 mark:** The contrast between the **active, comfortable verbs** (“bottle, recycle, pay”) and the **strenuous, dependent verbs** (“walk, queue, ration”) makes the **gap between rich and poor** feel sharp, deliberate and unavoidable.

**Q20. [2]** — “A pipe network is a moral document”

**1 mark:** The writer means that the way a city **lays its pipes** — who is connected, who is not — **reveals its values and priorities**, not just its engineering.

**1 mark:** A pipe network **records** the city’s **decisions about fairness** — which neighbourhoods receive supply and which are left to private vendors — and therefore carries **moral consequences**, not only technical ones.

**Q21. [1]** — Tone of the final sentence

**1 mark** — Any **one** of: **cautionary, reflective, urgent but measured, humbling, admonitory**. (Reject: **angry, despairing** — these miss the calm, instructive quality.)

**Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]**

**Content points** ( $\frac{1}{2}$  mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

**Causes of water scarcity (Paragraphs 2–3, 5):**

1. **Rapid urban population growth** across Asian cities outpaces what utilities can supply.
2. **Old, leaking infrastructure** loses a large share of treated water before it reaches taps.
3. **Climate change** lengthens dry seasons and disrupts monsoon rainfall.
4. **Over-extraction and pollution of groundwater** by industry, fertiliser and sewage.
5. **Unequal distribution** — the poor pay more and queue longer than the rich for the same water.

**Responses to the problem (Paragraphs 4, 6):**

6. **Desalination and recycling** — including Singapore’s NEWater, which meets up to 40% of demand.
7. **Greywater reuse and mandatory rainwater harvesting** in new buildings.
8. **Smart meters and leak-detection sensors** are being fitted to old networks.

**Sample full-marks summary (78 words):**

**Asian cities are running short of water because** their populations are expanding faster than utilities can cope, ageing pipes lose vast quantities, climate change is disrupting rainfall, and groundwater is being over-pumped and polluted. Supply is also distributed unfairly, with the poor paying most. Responses include cheaper desalination, large-scale recycling such as Singapore’s NEWater, compulsory rainwater harvesting and greywater reuse in new buildings, and the slow fitting of smart meters and leak sensors onto old networks.

**Length count: 78 words from “Asian” onwards.**

**— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —**